

A FEATURE FILM

THE GRASP

All the time in the world.

FEATURE BIBLE

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AT A GLANCE

Title	The Grasp
Format	Feature film, 101 pages
Genre	Folk horror / psychological drama
Setting	A crowded, clock-driven city, then Sommarøy, a small island off the coast of northern Norway where the sun never sets
Tone	Warm, bright, and quietly devastating. Horror built from kindness rather than menace.
Comparables	The Wicker Man, Midsommar, and the grief and ambiguity of The Leftovers
Cast	Two leads, one central supporting role, seven featured islanders, and a village
Tagline	All the time in the world.

LOGLINE

When a burned-out couple escapes to an Arctic island where the sun never sets, she surrenders to a warm, timeless community that gently lets its members disappear, while he clings to counting the days, until he learns the island has always needed someone to keep count.

Short Version

A couple fleeing their clock-driven lives finds an island without time, where the only way to stay is to let go, and the only way to leave is to be the one who remembers.

SYNOPSIS

Act One: The Clock

Lena and Jonas live by the alarm. They sprint for trains, answer emails in the dark, and ignore the red-striped envelopes piling up on the counter. Their jobs are eating them alive, and their relationship has shrunk to a tired look across a small apartment every morning. Strange things flicker at the edges of their days: a subway clock that jumps from 9:01 back to 8:59, a banner ad that reads STOP THE CLOCK, a poster of children leaping from a dock into bright water. One night Jonas takes the ticking kitchen clock off the wall and lays it face down. Then he shows Lena an article about Sommarøy, a Norwegian island where time is said not to exist.

They quit, sell what they can, and board the 7:40 ferry out of Tromsø. It leaves at 7:46.

Act Two: The Welcome

The island greets them like family. Halvard, a quiet elder in a jacket buttoned to the throat, hands them a brass key. Sigrid feeds them. Erik pours aquavit. Maja paints flowers up Lena's arms. What follows is a festival that seems to last for days under a sun that never sets: long tables, cold swims, dancing, sleep in the grass at three in the morning. For the first time in years they're happy.

Then the music stops. The tables disappear, the villagers go back to ordinary life, and nobody mentions the party. When Jonas counts the dish towels from Sigrid's daily loaves, he finds nineteen. Nineteen days have passed that neither of them can account for. He starts a tally in his old work notebook. Soon another hand begins writing in it, an upright clerk's script that records what they've done and predicts what they'll do next.

Lena drifts the other way. She bakes with Sigrid, hums without noticing, and befriends Kari, a young Londoner who is quietly losing words: the name of her street, then her surname, then the word for a gull. Every villager, Lena realizes, was once an exhausted outsider like them. Halvard tells Jonas the island's one rule in the flat voice of a railway announcement: the boat only comes when somebody goes.

That night the village gathers in a double ring around a chalk spiral. Kari walks it barefoot, lies down at its center, and lets go while the village sings her to rest. Afterward, nobody will say her name except Halvard, who remembers all of them. He tells Jonas the ferry will come in four days. It always takes four.

Jonas builds his escape around that number. Lena lets him. The notebook writes, in real time, a line that neither of them can unsee: He will bring her to the circle.

Act Three: The Keeper

On the fourth morning, Lena disappears into the woods just as the ferry's engine sounds on the water. Jonas chooses her footprints over the boat and misses it by a minute. The ferry has brought a new couple. Lena is already welcoming them, painted to the elbows, pouring aquavit, saying Erik's words exactly.

Jonas comes apart. Halvard tells him the truth at last: he came in 1983 with his wife, Ingrid, who went into the circle that first summer. He boarded the next ferry, and it turned around on its own and brought him back to a harbor where the old keeper was waiting. He has counted for forty-three years. He's tired.

Lena comes home to say goodbye and makes Jonas the tea that finally lets him sleep. He wakes to a note: DON'T FOLLOW. He follows with a knife to her own half-finished spiral of carved stones in the woods. He means to stop it. Instead, she asks him to walk her in, and he does. When she is gone, in the silence where no one will ever say her name again, Jonas says it out loud. Halvard looks at him and nods.

The next morning, the names in the notebook are in Jonas's own handwriting. Four days later he boards the ferry. Lena appears at the tree line and raises a hand. The wheel turns by itself and carries him home. Halvard's stopped pocket watch hangs on the mooring post, and Halvard sits still on the harbor steps.

Some time later, a ferry brings a burned-out couple to the island. Jonas meets them at the dock with his coat buttoned to the throat. "Which boat did you take from Tromsø?"

THEMES

Time as a cage we built ourselves

Act One is a catalogue of small tyrannies: alarms, notifications, deadlines, boxes drawn around boxes. Nothing in it is villainous. It's simply how people live now. The island offers the obvious cure, a place without clocks, and the film asks what that cure would really cost.

Surrender and control

Lena and Jonas answer the island in opposite ways. She surrenders to it, and he tries to measure it. The island accepts both answers. Surrender leads to release, and control leads to the keeper's chair. Neither of them escapes, because the island has a use for each of them.

The mercy of forgetting, and the weight of remembering

The island's gift is forgetting. Pain fades, names fade, and people put down what they've been carrying. But somebody has to hold the names. The keeper is the one person on the island who isn't allowed to forget, and the film's final horror is that Jonas takes on the job out of love.

Horror through kindness

Nobody on the island locks a door or raises a hand. Everyone is warm, funny, and helpful. The dread comes from generosity: the sweaters that fit, the bread that's always warm, a festival thrown for strangers. The island never needs to trap anyone. It only needs to be better than the life they left.

The grasp

The title lives in the characters' hands. Lena and Jonas find each other's hands in the dark before they leave. In the cabin, she pulls his hand to her chest and holds on. His hand is on the door when she tries to follow a ghost into the rain. At the end of the spiral, her hand slips out of his like it was never really there. The film is about what we hold on to, and what it costs to let go.

TONE AND STYLE

Light

There is no night on the island. The light is flat, bright, and slightly overexposed, and nothing casts much of a shadow. Torches burn in broad daylight because they look nice. The unease comes from the absence of darkness: no time to hide, no time to rest, no signal that a day has ended. The only dark room in the film is the cabin after Jonas nails a blanket over the window, and even then the light leaks in around the edges.

Act One is the visual opposite. It's cramped and fluorescent, full of screens, tunnels, and blacked-out subway windows.

Sound

The soundtrack of Act One is clocks: alarms, ticking, calendar pings, printers, a subway chime. The island replaces them with a small vocabulary of sounds that the audience learns to read.

Sound	Meaning
The hum	Many voices holding one long note. It is the sound of the released, and it gains one voice each time someone goes.
Three notes	A subway door chime in Act One. Maja hums the same three notes on the dock. The fiddler taps his foot three times before he plays, and the knocking on the cabin walls comes in threes.
The fiddle tuning	The sound of an arrival. When the fiddle tunes up at the harbor, a boat is coming.
The single bell	Heard once on the path from the harbor the first day, and once more in the film's final moment. No one ever finds the tower.

Dialogue

The islanders talk like ordinary people. They are practical, funny, a little nosy, and full of habits from the lives they left. Nobody speaks in riddles or prophecy. The wrongness leaks through small slips: Maja delighting in the word Tuesday, Tomas flinching at a kettle whistle, Sigrid asking "Who, love?" about a woman who died the night before.

The only formal language in the film is Halvard's ritual line, recited in an older Norwegian he inherited from the keeper before him and heard exactly twice:

You have carried enough. Put it down. We will carry the rest.

Comparables

The Wicker Man gives us the outsider on an island whose community has already decided his fate.

Midsommar gives us endless Scandinavian daylight, ritual, and a relationship coming apart.

The Leftovers gives us the register: grief, ambiguity, and a refusal to explain the supernatural.

What sets *The Grasp* apart is its engine. The island is about time, and its horror is seduction rather than capture. Nobody forces anyone to stay. The ending isn't an escape or a sacrifice but a succession.

THE WORLD OF THE ISLAND

Sommarøy

Sommarøy is a small fishing island west of Tromsø, reached by a short ferry run. It has red boathouses, a harbor wall, a market square, a long wooden hall with high windows, a shop, scattered cabins, birch woods, and a cliff path above the sea. It's a handsome, ordinary place, and that's the point.

The real Sommarøy made international headlines in 2019 when its residents proposed becoming a "time-free zone." The film's island is a heightened, fictional version of that idea. If needed for clearances, it can be renamed without changing the story.

The Rules

These rules are never explained on screen. The audience pieces them together, and every scene is written to be consistent with them.

1. **Everyone came from somewhere else.** There are no natives. Every villager was once an exhausted outsider who arrived by ferry.
2. **The island calls the exhausted.** It reaches out through ads, articles, and glitches in the clocks of their old lives. They believe they found it themselves.
3. **It is always summer.** The light never ends, whatever season it is on the mainland.
4. **Every arrival gets a festival.** It happens only when newcomers arrive and lasts until they have lost track of the days. Then it stops, and nobody mentions it again.
5. **Release.** When someone has let go completely, the village gathers in a double ring around a spiral. The keeper pours seawater from the wooden bowl, and the person stops breathing. Their belongings are burned.
6. **The hum is the released.** After each release, the hum carries one more voice. The released can still be glimpsed at the edges of things: children on the dock, a woman at the tree line in the rain.
7. **The name is not spoken.** After a release, the name is never spoken again. Some villagers truly forget. Others pretend.
8. **The keeper remembers.** Only the keeper remembers every name, knows the day for each newcomer, and keeps the count. The keeper's hand is the one that writes in the notebook.

9. **The ferry comes when somebody goes.** It arrives four days after a release, bringing the next arrivals. Anybody can board it. The island decides where it goes.
10. **Succession.** The keeper is succeeded by the newcomer who fought hardest and counted most, and who says a released name aloud.

CHARACTERS

The Couple

LENA *late 20s*

A designer at a creative agency who has spent five years doing math in the dark: rent, deadlines, hours until the alarm. She's warm, funny, and running on empty. Even in the city, her body answers to steadiness. In a stalled subway car, the idling drone of the motor calms her while everyone else checks their watches.

On the island she's the one who stops fighting. She bakes with Sigrid, befriends Kari, and learns the village's rhythms before she knows she's learning them. Her arc is a surrender the audience understands, even as it terrifies them. By the end she's painting the arms of the next newcomer and saying the words that were once said to her. She goes into the circle by choice, and she asks Jonas to walk her in.

Key line: "I used to lie awake doing math. I haven't done math in weeks."

JONAS *early 30s*

An analyst who lives in his calendar and draws boxes around boxes in a black work notebook. He's the one who proposes leaving, and the one who books the boat. On the island, once the festival ends, he's the one who can't stop counting.

Jonas believes measurement will protect him. He counts the towels, tallies the days, and builds his whole escape around Halvard's four days. The island takes that instinct and uses it. His fight to leave is exactly what qualifies him to stay. In the end he gives up the fight for love: he drinks the tea, walks Lena into the spiral, and says her name. That makes him the keeper.

Key line: "Somebody should."

The Keeper

HALVARD *70s*

The island's elder. He was once a railway traffic controller at Oslo Central who knew where every train in the city was to the minute. He arrived in 1983 on the 7:40 ferry with his wife, Ingrid. She went into the circle that first summer. He boarded the next boat, and it turned around and brought him back to a harbor where the old keeper was waiting.

He has counted for forty-three years. He speaks in short, practical sentences, usually instructions, and he never explains the island. He checks a pocket watch that stopped decades ago. He watches Jonas from the first handshake because he recognizes him. He's a mirror of Jonas's future, and the film's quiet tragedy.

Key line: "I remember all of them."

The Islanders

SIGRID *50s*

A former hospice nurse from Bergen who came alone after a divorce. She feeds everyone, asks about sleep and appetite the way a nurse takes a history, and takes pulses out of habit. She is also the one who checks for the last heartbeat at every release. She remembers everyone and pretends not to. Her kindness and her grief are the same thing.

KARI *late 20s*

A former London derivatives trader who worked in milliseconds. She has an unfinished infinity tattoo, a gap left in one loop, which she got the week she quit and meant to finish once she understood what forever meant. When we meet her she's losing words: her street, her surname, the word for a gull. She is lucid, gentle, and entirely unafraid, and she gives Lena her scarf the way you'd lend a finished book. At her release, Maja closes the gap in the tattoo with ash.

ERIK *30s*

A former North Sea oil platform worker who lived by shift bells and still hears them sometimes. He's terse and dry, fixes engines, and argues about outboard motors. He is the most recent arrival before Lena and Jonas and the only true fence-sitter. The ferry came for him once, and he stood on the landing and didn't get on. He stops Jonas at Kari's release and steps aside for him at Lena's.

MAJA *20s*

A former Stockholm social media manager who burned out at twenty-three and converted harder than anyone. She's eager, chatty, and still talks in the language of her old life. She hums three notes constantly, carves birds obsessively, and paints every newcomer's arms. She is the island's most sincere believer. After Kari's release she genuinely doesn't remember it.

TOMAS *40s*

A former line cook and sous chef from Copenhagen, now the island's fishmonger. He calls "behind" when no one's in his way, flinches at a kettle whistle the way he once flinched at kitchen timers, and still carries an old laminated ID badge in his apron. He's the one islander who sees Lena clearly, because he remembers being her. He slips once, saying "She liked the cliff," and corrects himself.

DECLAN *50s*

A former cruise ship entertainer from Cork who works the harbor like a stage. He catches the bow line with a flourish, makes every announcement, and deflects

every serious question with a joke about fuel costs or flexible tickets. He knows exactly how the ferry works and will never say so plainly.

ASTRID 70s

A former bank teller from Gothenburg who runs the island shop on the principle that "we settle up when we remember." She's the second-longest resident after Halvard and the only one left who knew Ingrid.

Others

THE NEW ARRIVALS

Two couples, one arriving mid-story and one in the final scene, who mirror Lena and Jonas exactly: city clothes, one suitcase, a phone frozen at 11:52. They let the audience see the cycle from the outside.

THE CITY

Jonas's boss, Lena's manager, co-workers, a barista, and Lena's mother by text. They're sketched lightly and never cruel, only part of a machine that nobody controls.

MOTIFS AND OBJECTS

The script is built on plants and payoffs. Almost every object introduced on the island returns with a second meaning.

Object	Where it starts	Where it lands
The kitchen clock	Jonas takes it off the wall, leaving a nail and a pale circle (Sc. 7)	The same pale ring above the cabin table on the first day (Sc. 12)
8:59	The subway clock jumps back to 8:59 (Sc. 2)	Lena's abandoned watch returns, stopped at 8:59 (Sc. 39)
7:40 / 7:46	Jonas books the 7:40; the terminal clock reads 7:46 as they depart (Sc. 7D, 10)	Halvard: "It always does" (Sc. 11). His watch stops at 7:46 (Sc. 52). Jonas repeats the line (Sc. 53)
The black notebook	Boxes around boxes in a meeting (Sc. 3); pocketed on the last day (Sc. 8)	The tally (Sc. 17); the clerk's hand (Sc. 20); names in Jonas's own hand (Sc. 50)
Sigrid's dish towels	A loaf wrapped in a towel on the table (Sc. 12)	Nineteen towels (Sc. 17); a bandage (Sc. 44); four towels, four days (Sc. 50)
Threes	Subway chime (Sc. 2); Maja's hum (Sc. 11); the fiddler's three taps (Sc. 13)	Three knocks on the walls (Sc. 25); the music starts for the new arrivals (Sc. 43)
The fiddle tuning	Tuning up at the long table (Sc. 13)	"That's how you always know it's the boat" (Sc. 28); the ferry arrives (Sc. 42)
The spiral	Worked into the brass key (Sc. 11); cut inside the wardrobe (Sc. 12)	Kari's carved disc (Sc. 26); the chalk spiral (Sc. 32); Lena's stones (Sc. 43, 49)
The bowl and the knife	Found together in the wardrobe (Sc. 12)	The bowl oiled (Sc. 30) and poured (Sc. 32, 49); the knife taken, then dropped (Sc. 47, 49)
The sweaters	Cream and charcoal, in their exact sizes (Sc. 12)	Rows of them in every size in the shed (Sc. 19); the cream one burned (Sc. 49)

Object	Where it starts	Where it lands
Kari's gray scarf	Given to Lena on the cliff (Sc. 23)	Left on the pillow (Sc. 47); worn by Lena at the tree line as Jonas's pocket comes up empty (Sc. 51)
Halvard's pocket watch	A chain in his pocket at the festival (Sc. 14)	Checked out of habit (Sc. 30); left on the mooring post for Jonas (Sc. 52)
Kari's tea	Herbs from the cliff; Lena sleeps, Jonas pours his out (Sc. 23)	Jonas drinks it, knowing what it means (Sc. 46)
Hands	Lena finds Jonas's hand in the dark (Sc. 10)	Held to her chest (Sc. 41); slipping out of his in the spiral (Sc. 49)

STRUCTURE

The script runs 101 pages across 53 numbered scenes.

Sequence	Scenes	What happens
The Clock	1 to 6	Lena and Jonas on the treadmill of city life. The first glitches: 8:59, STOP THE CLOCK, the ferry notification, the poster of children on a dock.
The Decision	7 to 7D	The clock comes off the wall. The Sommarøy article. "Then we hate it together." The 7:40 is booked.
Departure	8 to 10	Quitting, packing, leaving the watch and the work ID behind. The ferry leaves at 7:46.
The Welcome	11 to 15	Arrival, the cabin, the long table, the festival montage, and Kari's toast across the bonfire.
The Count	16 to 22	The music stops. Nineteen towels. The notebook begins writing in another hand. The children on the dock. "It came."
Kari	23 to 31	Lena's friendship with Kari as Kari loses her words. The notebook informs on both of them. Halvard: "When somebody goes."
Midpoint	32	Kari's release in the chalk spiral.
The Countdown	33 to 41	"Somebody went." Four days. The storm, the bundle of their old lives, "He will bring her to the circle," and "I'm not going."
Ferry Day	42 to 43	Jonas chooses Lena's footprints over the boat and misses it by a minute. Lena welcomes the new arrivals.
The Breaking	44 to 46	Jonas comes apart. Halvard's story. Lena's goodbye, and the tea.
The Spiral	47 to 49	DON'T FOLLOW. The hunt. "Walk me in." Lena's release, and Jonas says her name.
The Keeper	50 to 53	The names in his own hand. The ferry turns back. Halvard's watch. The new arrivals and "It always does."

THE ENDING

The Grasp ends in succession, not escape or sacrifice.

Lena's release is her choice, and the film honors it. She isn't tricked or taken. She has found the rest she was starving for, and she asks the person she loves to walk her there. The notebook's prophecy, "He will bring her to the circle," comes true in the most painful way possible: freely, and out of love.

Jonas's transformation turns on a single word. In the silence where the island's rule says no one will ever speak her name again, he says "Lena." Remembering is the keeper's job, and he has just taken it on. Halvard sees it and nods. The next morning, the names in the notebook are in Jonas's own handwriting, and the audience understands that the clerk's hand was always the keeper's.

The ferry gives Jonas his one real chance to leave, and he takes it. The island turns the boat around. This time he doesn't fight. He walks to the bow and faces home. Halvard, relieved at last, goes quietly on the harbor steps, and his watch is left for his successor, stopped at 7:46.

The coda replays the film's first arrival shot for shot, with Jonas standing where Halvard stood. The audience knows everything the new couple doesn't. The last sound is the same single bell from the first day.

The film never explains what the island is. It could be a place, a purgatory, or the shape exhaustion takes when it's finally allowed to rest. The rules are consistent, and the mystery stays intact.

PRODUCTION NOTES

Contained and achievable

The film's weight rests on two leads and one central supporting role, with seven featured islanders and a village of forty to fifty extras for the festival and ritual scenes. After Act One, nearly everything takes place in a single island location: the harbor, the square, one cabin interior, the hall, a shop, the woods, and a cliff path.

No night shoots

The island's endless daylight is a creative choice and also a practical advantage. Everything after Act One is written for natural or controlled daylight. The cabin's single dim scene is lit by light leaking around a blanket over the window.

Locations

Northern Norway during the midnight sun season is the ideal home. Comparable northern coastlines with birch woods, fishing harbors, and long summer light would also work, including Iceland, the Scottish islands, and Atlantic Canada. Act One can be shot in almost any major city.

Language

The film is in English. The islanders come from all over northern Europe, and their accents are part of how the audience works out that nobody was born here. A small amount of Norwegian is subtitled, including Halvard's ritual line.

Key set pieces

The festival montage and long table, the midpoint release in the chalk spiral, the storm, the ferry turning around on its own, and the final spiral in the woods.